



BURROWING SQUIRRELS

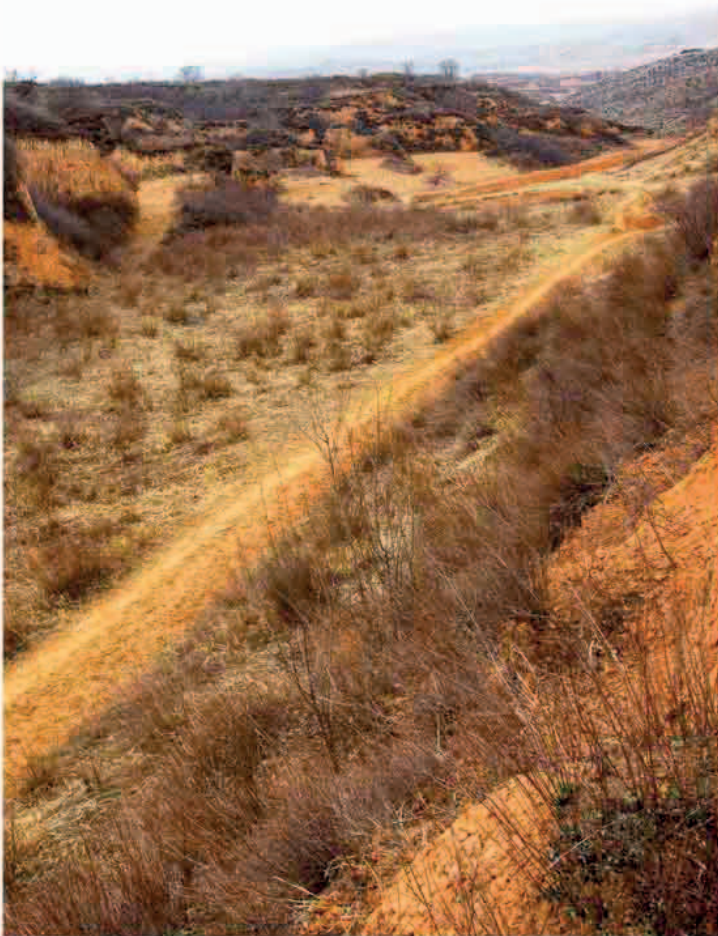
The grazing herds are the most obvious grassland animals, but they are outnumbered by small burrowing mammals such as ground squirrels and mole rats. Other burrowers include rattlesnakes, armadillos, foxes, weasels, and polecats. Even owls nest underground on the American prairies.

◀ LOWLIFE

Ground squirrels such as this prairie dog spend most of their time underground.

DUST BOWLS

Temperate grasslands can make excellent farmland. But the soil of prairies and steppes tends to dry out, and if there is not enough natural vegetation to hold it together, it can turn to dust and blow away. This happened in the American Midwest in the 1930s, creating a large barren area known as the Dust Bowl. It also took place over a far longer period in China, where the windblown soil has formed thick drifts that cover huge areas.



▲ LOESS PLATEAU

In Shanxi Province, China, an area almost the size of Texas is covered by a thick layer of windblown soil known as loess.

FACT!

American prairie dogs live in underground colonies called towns. In the past, these could be huge—one found in 1900 was home to an estimated 400 million prairie dogs.



NIBBLING TEETH

Although many grasslands have been destroyed by farming, others have been created. As farm animals like these sheep nibble the vegetation, they kill off many plants, especially trees. But the grass keeps growing, and gradually takes over the landscape. Large areas of wild-looking grassland have been created like this, and if the sheep are taken off the land, the trees grow back.

